



repeats. "If Satwik and Chirag are in good form, they can beat anyone," he says.

India's women's and mixed doubles pairs are underdogs, but that may not be a bad thing.

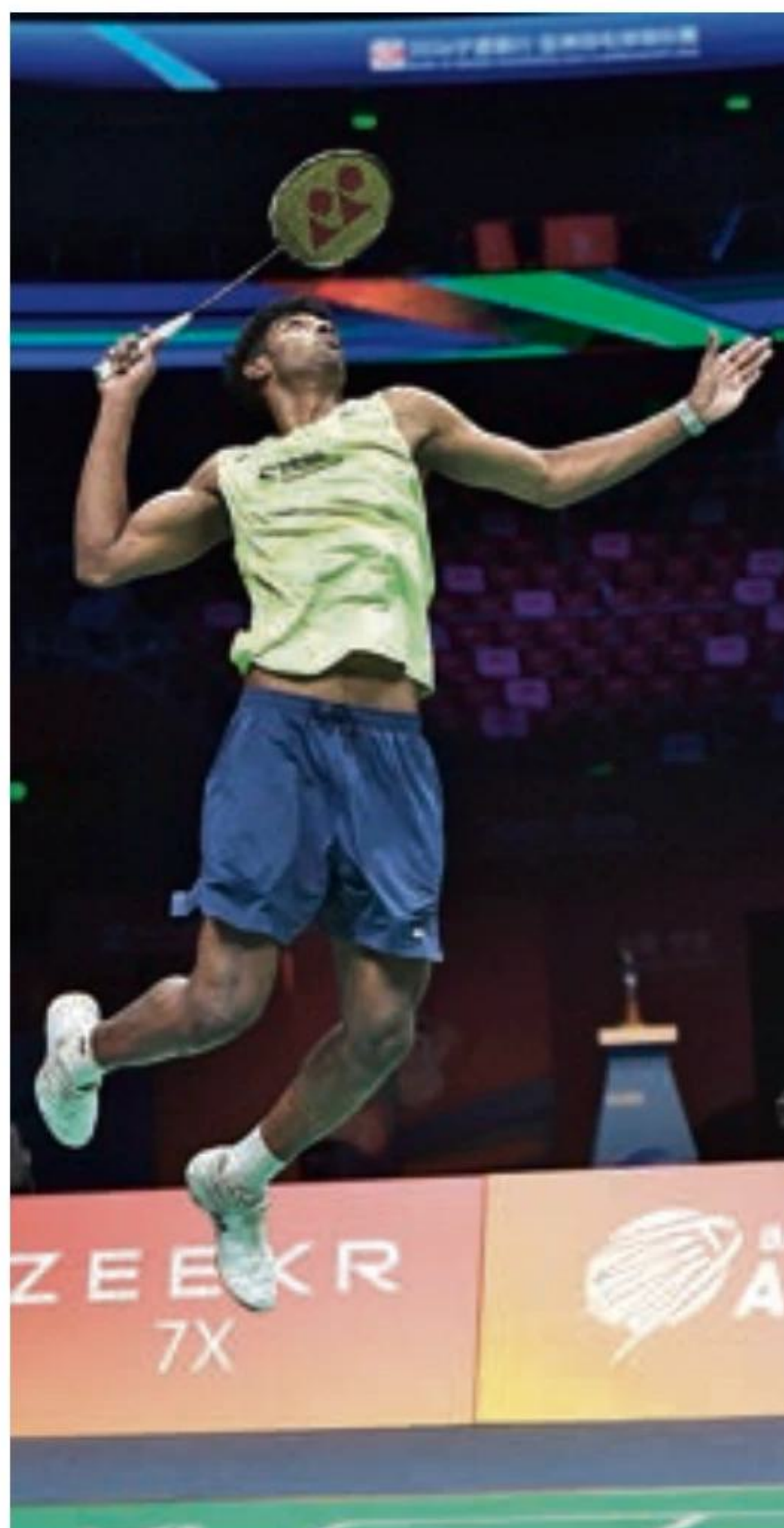
Take India's women's doubles pair of Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand, for example.

The two barely played in recent months after Treesa got injured due to a collision in training. Their return came only at the Philippines International Challenge earlier this month.

The title win matters less than the competitive matches it gave the pair immediately before the World Championships. Their lack of ranking points from the layoff means they enter unseeded, but that could potentially make them dangerous.

Gopichand believes the pair may actually have an advantage over players who have spent the year travelling relentlessly on the BWF circuit. "They don't have the exhaustion that other pairs will have from the hectic world tour," he says.

India has produced success in



Tough draw: Ayush Shetty will face top seed and defending champion Shi Yu Qi of China in the first round.

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Opening hurdle: In the women's doubles, two-time All England semifinalists Gayatri Gopichand and Treesa Jolly will be up against Paula Lopez and Lucia Rodriguez of Spain in the first round. GETTY IMAGES

women's doubles at the World Championships before. Back in 2011, Jwala Gutta and Ashwini Ponnappa won bronze, becoming the first Indian women's doubles pair to medal at the event. They, too, had been unseeded. Perhaps Treesa and Gayatri could produce their own surprise.

There is also a mixed doubles challenge, with 15th seeds Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto facing a difficult route that could bring them up against sixth seeds Guo Xin Wa and Chen Fang Hui of China in the pre-quarterfinals.

Organisers will hope these individual stories capture attention. But as the World Championships return to India, talk of anything other than the badminton on court will be a distraction that the sport will do well to avoid.